Screen Free Rewards

Parent guide. Every screen, every control, and what the app can and cannot do.

Version 1.6.0

What this app does. Children earn points for time away from screens. Parents set the earning windows, approve points, decide reward requests, read a daily summary by email and see screen time. You can edit or delete every piece of information the app stores.

An important limit. Screen Free Rewards is a web app. A web app can track time spent in itself and apps a parent logs by hand, and it can lock itself. It cannot see or block other apps or lock the whole phone: phones only allow that to a native companion app with special permissions. This guide marks clearly what works now and what needs the companion.

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1. Getting started

There are two ways to open the app. Choose at the top of the first screen.

On the child's device: Child's device

- Enter your name, your email (every notification goes here) and, if you like, a second parent's email and your mobile number.
- Choose a parent PIN (4 to 8 digits). It opens Parent controls on the child's device. Keep it secret.
- Enter the child's name, age and their own PIN (4 to 8 digits). The two PINs must be different.
- Press Start. Each parent email is confirmed once: the app emails a 6-digit code and you type it in. Only confirmed emails receive notifications.
- A pairing code appears so you can connect your own phone straight away (see below). You can skip it and do it later in Parent controls, Apps.

On the parent's own phone: My phone (parent)

- On the child's device open Parent controls, then Apps, then Show pairing code. The code looks like K7QM-4TXD and works for 15 minutes.
- On your phone open the app, choose My phone (parent), type your name and the code, and press Connect. You only do this once.
- Your phone now shows the child's screen time and app list, and can lock the device or apps. Up to 4 parent phones can connect to one child's device, and one phone can follow several children.

Welcome bonus. Every new child starts with 50 points. It is added once when the child is created and counted as earned in that day's summary email.

Family file. Parent controls, Data, Download my data saves children, points, tasks and parents to a file. On a new device choose I have a family file on the first screen (or Load a family file in Data) to restore them. Email links, codes and pairing are never loaded from a file.

Put it on the phone. Open the app address in the phone browser. Android Chrome: menu, Install app. iPhone Safari: Share, Add to Home Screen. It then opens full screen with its own icon and works offline. Android and iOS app projects are in the mobile folder of the package.

Siblings. Add more children in Parent controls, Siblings. Each child has their own points, tasks, rewards, requests and PIN. They share the same device and the same parent emails.

2. The child's screen

ITEM	WHAT IT DOES
Timer ring	Shows the time of the current session. The ring fills as the day's screen-free minutes use up the scheduled window.
Start / Stop	Starts the screen-free timer. It only starts inside an earning window set by the parent. Stopping collects the points: 1 point per full minute. The points wait for a parent to approve them.
Screen time today	The total shown under the ring. With the companion app it is all apps on the phone. Without it, it is time in this app plus apps a parent logged by hand. The note under the number says which.
Redeem points	The child picks a reward the parent added. The points are held, the parents get an email, and the parent approves or declines. Declining refunds the points.
Ask parents / Suggest reward	Sends a free-text request. A suggested reward becomes a real reward when a parent approves it and sets its cost.
Tasks	Tasks assigned by a parent appear under the buttons. Tapping Done adds the points straight away and emails the parents.
Parent controls	Opens with the parent PIN only.

Locked screen. When a parent locks the device the child sees a full-screen lock with the parent's message. It can only be removed from a parent phone or with the parent PIN on the device.

3. Parent controls, tab by tab

Open with the Parent controls button and the parent PIN. Every list has Edit and Delete buttons.

TAB	WHAT YOU CAN DO
Overview	Balance, pending points (with an Approve points button), minutes screen free today, open requests, a 7-day chart and recent activity.
Schedule	Earning windows by day type and time. Edit or delete any window. With no windows the timer works at any time.
Reconciliation	Compares the scheduled minutes with the minutes actually timed. Log time in other apps by hand here; each entry can be edited or deleted and counts toward the screen time totals.
Tasks	Add tasks with points. Edit the title, points or status, or delete a task.
Requests	Approve or decline asks, suggestions and redeems. Each request can be deleted. A redeem that is still waiting is refunded if you delete it.
Rewards	The rewards a child can redeem. Add, edit (name, cost, description) or delete.
Siblings	Add children, switch between them, edit a name, age or PIN, or delete a child and all of their data.
Profile	Parent names, emails, mobile numbers, who gets emails, notification choices, the daily or weekly summary, email confirmation status and the Send test email button.

TAB	WHAT YOU CAN DO
Reports	Email today's summary now, preview it, download the summary PDF, or the activity and points PDFs.
Apps	Screen time today and for 7 days, the app list with Lock buttons, the device lock, and the pairing code for parent phones.
Data	This guide, a file with all your data, adjust points, delete sessions or log entries, change the parent PIN, and erase everything.

4. Emails and notifications

Each family receives its own emails, only at the addresses its parents entered and confirmed. Emails are sent by the mail relay that the app owner runs, from one Google account, so the sender is the same for every family.

EMAIL	WHEN
Points earned	Sent when a timer session ends with points. Can be switched off in Profile.
Task completed	Sent when the child taps Done on a task. Can be switched off in Profile.
Requests and redeems	Always sent, with the PDF report attached.
Daily summary	Set Send log every to Daily or Weekly. It is sent after 20:00 while the app is open on the device. You can also press Email today's summary at any time.
Verification code	Sent once per parent email when you set up or press Verify in Profile.

What is in the PDF report

One A4 page in the same layout as the email: balance, pending, earned today and screen free minutes, then Child, Points, Screen-free time, open requests and tasks, activity and a short commentary.

Limits. A free Google account can send about 100 emails a day for all families together (about 1,500 with Google Workspace). That suits a small first group. For many families the owner should move the relay to an email service; the app does not change.

5. Screen time, app tracking and remote lock

This is the part where being clear matters. The table shows what is built and tested in this version and what needs the companion app.

CAPABILITY	STATUS	NOTES
Total screen time in this app	Works now	Counted while the child's home screen of the app is open and visible.
Time in other apps, logged by a parent	Works now	Parent logs the minutes in Reconciliation. They appear in the totals and the app list.
Screen time shown to the child	Works now	Under the timer ring, labelled with its source.

CAPABILITY	STATUS	NOTES
Pairing parent phones, once	Works now	Code from the child's device, typed on the parent phone.
See usage from the parent phone	Works now	Refreshes every 30 seconds while the parent phone app is open.
Lock the app on the child's device	Works now	Full-screen lock, applied within about 30 seconds while the app is open on the child's device.
Lock list for other apps	Saved now	Choices are stored and sent. Blocking happens only with the companion app.
Time in every app on the phone	Needs companion	Phones only share this with a native app that has Usage Access (Android) or Screen Time (iPhone).
Block other apps, lock the whole phone	Needs companion	Needs Accessibility and Device Admin on Android, or Screen Time controls on iPhone.

How the lock works on the child's device

- From your phone or the Apps tab press Lock device now. You can add a message.
- The child's device checks for changes every 30 seconds while the app is open and visible, then shows the lock.
- If the app is closed on the child's device it cannot receive the lock until it is opened again. Only a native companion can lock a closed phone.
- To unlock: press Unlock device on your phone, or enter the parent PIN on the lock screen.

The companion app

The companion is a small native app on the child's phone. It reads which apps were used and for how long, reports totals to the same sync link, and enforces the locks you choose. The sync link already accepts its reports and returns the lock settings, so adding it later needs no change to the family's setup. It is a separate project and is not part of this release.

6. Editing and deleting your information

INFORMATION	HOW TO CHANGE OR DELETE IT
Parent details	Profile: change names, emails, mobile numbers and options, then Save profile.
Parent PIN	Data, Parent PIN: enter the current PIN and a new one.
A child	Siblings: Edit changes name, age and PIN. Delete removes the child and all of their data (not available for the only child).
Points	Data, Adjust points: add or remove points with a reason. The change is written to the activity log.
Tasks, rewards, windows	Their tabs: Edit or Delete on each item.
Requests	Requests: Delete on any item.
Logged app time	Reconciliation: Edit or Delete on each entry.
Sessions	Data, Sessions: delete a session from the history. Points already earned stay; use Adjust points to change the balance.
Activity log	Data, Activity log: delete single entries or clear the whole log.
Everything	Data, Erase everything on this device. Needs the parent PIN. It also disconnects the parent phones.
A copy of your data	Data, Download my data: a file with everything stored on this device.

7. Privacy and where data lives

- Children, points, tasks, rewards, requests, history and settings are stored on the device where you set up the app. They are not copied to a server.
- Emails go through the owner's mail relay to the addresses you confirmed. The relay does not store the message, but the Sent folder of the Google account that sends the mail may keep a copy.
- For parent phones the relay stores only: a random room, the child's first name, the last 7 days of screen time numbers, the lock settings, and when the device was last seen. Disconnect all parent phones, or Erase everything, deletes that room.
- A relay link is needed for emails and phone pairing. If you use a family-specific link, only you can see this data.
- Anyone who knows the parent PIN can open Parent controls. Choose a PIN the children cannot guess and change it if it leaks.

8. Troubleshooting

PROBLEM	WHAT TO DO
I did not get the verification code	Check the spam folder. Codes last 10 minutes and you can ask for 4 a day per address. Use Verify in Profile to ask again.
Emails stopped	Open Profile and check both emails show Verified. If the owner's daily email limit is reached, emails resume the next day.
The parent phone says not connected	The child's device may have disconnected it. On the child's device press Show pairing code and connect again.
The lock did not appear	The app must be open and visible on the child's device. Wait up to 30 seconds. Closed apps cannot receive a lock.
Screen time looks too low	Without the companion it counts only this app and what you log. Log other apps in Reconciliation.
The timer will not start	The child must be inside an earning window. Check Schedule.
PDF buttons fail	The Activity and Points PDFs need an internet connection. The summary and this guide work offline.
I forgot the parent PIN	On the sign-in screen choose Forgot PIN: it asks for the parent PIN, so write it down. If it is lost, clearing this site's data in the browser settings deletes everything and lets you set up again.

Screen Free Rewards v1.6.0. This guide describes this version only.